



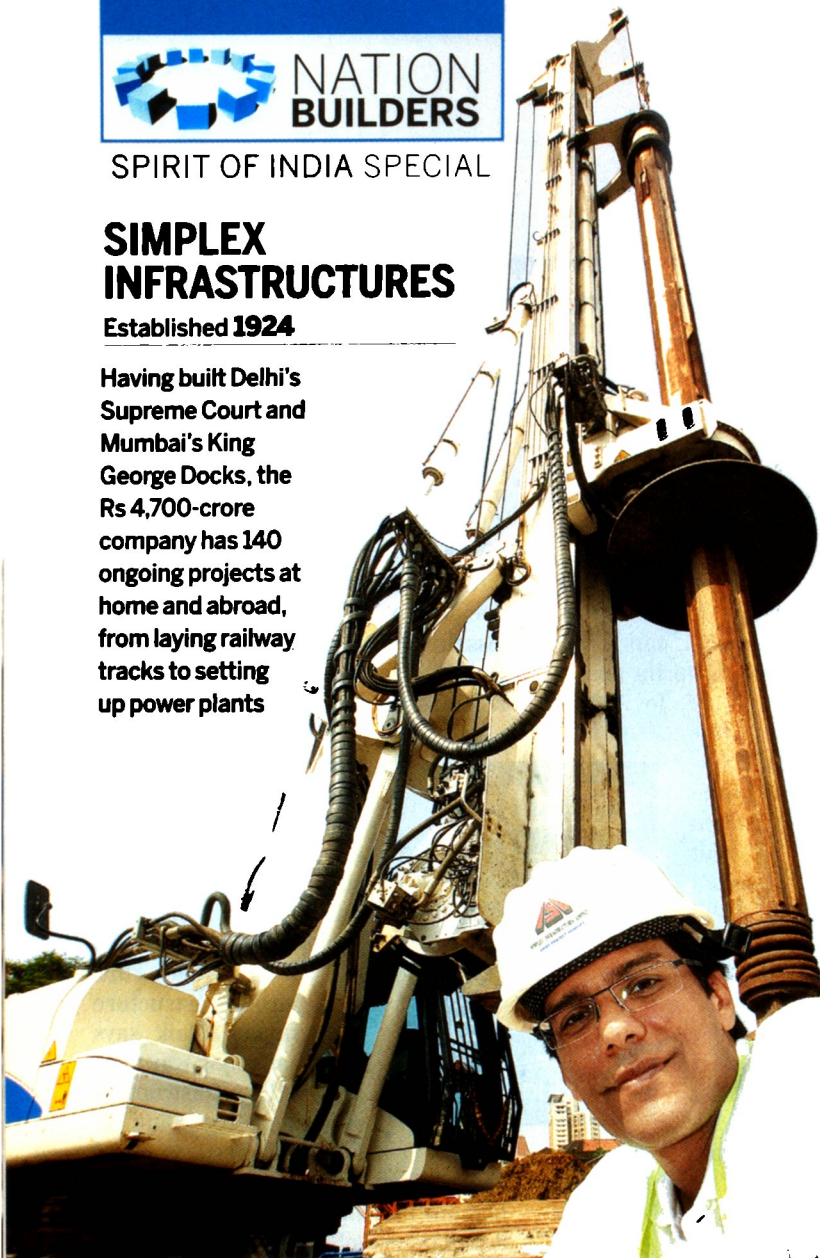
**NATION
BUILDERS**

SPIRIT OF INDIA SPECIAL

SIMPLEX INFRASTRUCTURES

Established 1924

Having built Delhi's Supreme Court and Mumbai's King George Docks, the Rs 4,700-crore company has 140 ongoing projects at home and abroad, from laying railway tracks to setting up power plants



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Amitabh Das Mundhra 42, Director

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the Jamnagar refinery for Reliance Industries in 1997. The Rs 4,700-crore company has an order book of over Rs 10,000 crore with 140 ongoing projects in India and overseas. With 30 per cent of its turnover coming from its international business in countries like Doha, Muscat and Dubai. Simplex has been making profits and paying dividends right since its inception.

The company's diversifications, both within the business as well as geographically, have helped it de-risk and carried it through the slump. It also owns the machinery and equipment that improves its profit margins. According to Mundhra, industries tend to go through a paradigm shift about every five years, and he says they will reinvent themselves again in 2015. However, as the company and the industry readies itself for the next phase of infrastructure growth, the supply side has to keep pace. "Manpower and training of manpower are huge constraints and there is a need to churn out more civil engineers," he says. China is a country which has done this successfully.

The other roadblock is that the country is not creating iconic infrastructure anymore. "The size and the scale required by India is not happening yet," says Mundhra who loves playing golf and is trained in Indian classical music.

"We are doing things in small packages. By the time it is ready, it will already be time for an upgrade." For instance, many of the four-lane highways are being expanded to six-lane ones. "Why don't we think of the future and build eight-lane ones now?" he adds.

by Nandini Vaish

BUILDING BLOCKS

When you have built some of India's most iconic structures, such as the Supreme Court in Delhi (1949-50), the Mackintosh Burn Building (1928) and the approach passages to the Howrah Bridge in Kolkata (1938) and the King George Docks (early 1930s) in Mumbai, you don't consider yourself a company, but an institution, says Amitabh Das Mundhra, director of the 85-year-old Simplex Infrastructures.

Till 2002, the company was largely involved in piling work—it is still India's largest piling company, installing 10 lakh piles or pillars annually and setting up industrial and

power plants. In 2005, it diversified into marine, transportation, water supply and sanitation which includes the ongoing upgradation of the sewage supply in Kolkata. A year later, Simplex bagged the contract for doubling the railway track on the 150-km south-central railway line in the Guntakal-Raichur railways in Andhra Pradesh, of which 54 per cent has been completed. Simplex also constructed the first private sector steel plants at Tatanagar for Tata Steel in 1937 and

682 km

of new track was laid down by the Indian Railways from 1992 to 2002 as against 13,797 km by China in the same period.